

would be a police officer taking me straight to jail. In reality, I just had to prove again that I already paid my taxes. It was annoying, but I didn't get locked up for life. Catastrophizing can also cause us to hoard money because of all the bad things that could happen if we spend it or do the opposite and spend it all out of fear we won't get it again.

Should-ing and must-ing. This is highly intertwined with our own unreasonable expectations of ourselves. We think "I *should* be able to stop ordering takeout" or "I *must* pay off my debt as quickly as possible." When we can't live up to these self-imposed pressures, we are left with feelings of shame, guilt, or frustration.

All-or-nothing. This involves viewing things or evaluating ourselves in an "all good" or "all bad" manner, unwilling to accept ambiguity or "gray" areas. It's this type of thinking that keeps us from the radical middle. And many times, the "all-or-nothing" is completely arbitrary. We make up standards for how we should spend, and when we don't meet them, we give up on the bigger goal entirely. This is what has halted many of our friends from investing for their retirement. If they couldn't max out their Roth IRA or didn't have an employer offering a 401(k), it didn't feel worth it to them.

This list is not exhaustive, but it can help you understand your thinking patterns and how you rationalize your thoughts about and actions with spending. And with any one of these unhelpful thinking styles, curiosity is the best place to begin. When it comes to your behaviors around money, any one (or combination) of these unhelpful thinking styles may be at play. When you notice yourself catastrophizing your debt or minimizing the importance of caring about the future, you can simply ask what that thinking pattern is connected to. Or what from your experience is causing you to believe, reason, or act in this way. These questions allow you to get to the core issue and have greater success in implementing an informed response that targets the root.

Barriers: What's in the Way of Curiosity?

Self-reflection can be difficult and often doesn't come naturally. We have years (for some of us decades!) of life experiences, patterns of relating, and an established understanding of who we are (for better or worse) that frames our perceptions and how we interact with the world. To be fair,